

DEBATE'S CULTURE OF NARCISSISM

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Debate has long been fractured by what at the time were believed to be deep divisions. When I began debating at the very end of the 1960s, the stock issues approach, more rhetorical and more oriented towards the general public, was in the process of being displaced by policy making, a view of debate which was more analytical and more geared to expert audiences. In the early 1970s, hypothesis testing emerged as a challenge to the prevailing policy making orthodoxy. Gaming and *tabula rasa* perspectives came along a little later to offer their own slants on how debate should be done. Both of these paradigms helped to encourage the development of the "utopian counterplan" in the mid to late 1980s. At this point, the basic division seemed to be between those who believed policy realism to be an important aspect of debate and those who thought that debate should be more concerned with exploring "alternative futures."

These different schools of thought were first labeled "paradigms" by David Zarefsky. Borrowing his language from Kuhn's study of scientific revolutions, Zarefsky was suggesting that these various orientations within debate reflected fundamentally different philosophies or worldviews concerning the activity. This was an insightful way of describing debate's divisions, and it served to structure the basic way in which we viewed debate theory for a couple of decades. The debated differences and disagreements seemed deep, even fundamental or "paradigmatic" at the time. But in retrospect, they have come to seem more like minor quarrels within an essentially unchallenged consensus. Throughout the decades of the 1970s and 1980s, there was general agreement that debate should be highly analytic and expert-oriented. Research was viewed as the most important skill debate had to teach. The rapid and efficient delivery of large amounts of secondary source material was an absolutely dominant convention, and as a result, various technical skills which involved fast-talking and directly clashing with the specifics of an opponent's

position were indispensable. Topics had broadened, but it was still almost universally agreed that one needed to debate at least a "reasonable" version of the topic. And since the topics chosen for NDT debate were invariably propositions of policy, our activity continued to be known as "policy debate." CEDA did offer something of an institutional challenge during these years. But while I am certainly not an expert on the history of CEDA, my outsider's sense is that CEDA debaters rather rapidly reproduced the practices that their organization began in part as a reaction against. A far more radical division within the activity began to develop when "the kritik" burst onto the scene in September 1991. Fourteen years later, the split in debate between critical and policy approaches has gone beyond culture war to full-blown clash of civilizations.

This forum asks us to reflect on the prospects for healing this rift. To look ahead to my conclusion: I am not at all optimistic that this will happen any time soon. The two groups involved simply want to do debate in fundamentally different ways. Policy debaters, who do seem to remain a majority, have little reason to give ground, especially in light of the ongoing radicalization of critical approaches. And kritik debaters, in some ways, thrive on the split. They win, in significant measure, by continuing to shock and to disconcert their more traditional opponents with new frameworks and unforeseen approaches.

I will come back to this conclusion at the end of this essay, but before revisiting it, there are three preliminary questions which should help to illuminate the issue. First, what are the root disagreements among the competing camps? Second, how did we get here? And third, does it matter? What are the costs (and benefits) of our current fractionalization?

The policy and the kritik camps differ both on what we should debate about and how we should debate. The policy school continues to believe that we should debate a topic, and it prefers that the topic chosen be a proposition of public policy. In contrast, the critical school significantly devalues the importance of the topic. In its more extreme forms, it argues that we should debate not about remote issues of public policy but what we really care about most, issues that directly implicate our own lives. Even when kritik proponents don't go this far, they generally seek to displace the central focus of debate from policy

desirability (is the plan a good idea?) to something else. This "something else" can be assumptions or ideology, ethics or methodology, discourse or representations. But it almost always approaches the opposition obliquely. Instead of directly denying that the government should enact a given policy, kritiks tend to indict something about the way in which that action has been justified.

In terms of how we should debate, the policy school continues to favor heavy reliance on direct quotation from expert sources. It is also dominated by highly specialized techniques, including very rapid, highly efficient delivery, adapted to a very specialized audience of expert debate judges. Many kritik debaters do much the same thing, but some increasingly stress a heavy reliance on personal experience and testimony. They also often adopt a significantly slower, more rhetorical style.

How did we get here? The history of critical argument, over the past fourteen years, is one of constant mutation. In one early incarnation, kritiks were advanced as ways of challenging important but unexamined assumptions. Brian Lain went so far as to suggest an "assumption questioning" paradigm of critical argument. This focus on assumptions, however, is no longer central to very many critical debates. Much of the cachet of the kritik comes from constantly reinventing itself, so it was not too long before the questioning of assumptions became passé. Beyond fashion and novelty, there are fairly good reasons why a focus on assumptions rather than on plans posed difficulties. In justifying its plan, the affirmative will typically advance scores of different arguments. And each of those arguments is linked to assumptions of a more or less fundamental nature. Thus, in a typical debate, each side relies on hundreds, if not thousands, of implicit assumptions. A few of these assumptions may be critical to the ultimate policy conclusion that the plan is a good idea, but many are not. Undermining one assumption may discredit one argument, but the affirmative's final conclusion seldom rests on a single argument. Also, assumptions can rarely be completely confirmed or discredited--they are not won or lost like chess pieces.

Indeed, the things that we assume are those which it is most difficult, if not impossible, to convincingly establish. This is especially true of such basic ontological

issues as the existence of an external world, of other minds, and of causal relationships. Because of this, in most cases, the affirmative can neither prove, nor the negative disprove, many of the assumptions at play in a given debate. Nor, in most cases, is this necessary to establish the desirability of the affirmative plan. The chance that an assumption may be true (i.e., causation may exist) will be enough to justify endorsing a certain course of action.

In another early formulation, critical argument was deemed preferable because, unlike arguments resting on the illusory notion of policy fiat, it could have a real world political impact. This approach also seems to have waned in recent years, and it has done so for good reason. The idea of policy fiat is sometimes dismissed as utopian, but the notion that a winning ballot in a college debate round could trigger a world-transforming social movement borders on megalomania. Beyond college debate's few hundred active participants, some fraction of America's hundreds of millions probably has a vague intimation that something like college debate exists. (They do, after all, watch "The Apprentice.") But they are certainly not attentive to its outcomes, no newspaper reports debate results ("kritik of capitalism 3, capitalism 1 "), nor do they understand its intricacies. And those relative few who do know something about debate know that it is a competitive game and that a judge's ballot does not signify conviction or ideological conversion (as those of us who have voted for arguments like "nuclear war good" can readily attest.) People do not make fundamental moral and political judgments based on individual debate rounds; nor should they. Reflective people surely have better bases for their beliefs than the outcomes of fast, short, competitive debates.

The idea that debate ballots have a real world macro-political effect also comports quite poorly with the commitment to fair judging of debates. If the ballot has a real impact, the judge can hardly justify not voting for his or her own convictions, regardless of who really wins the debate. Finally, it should be noted that if vastly influential intellectuals like Michel Foucault have not succeeded in transforming society in accord with their criticisms, debaters parroting watered-down versions of Foucault in a debate round are hardly likely to do so.

Still another early critical theme was the emphasis on discourse. This one has proved more enduring, and it is more difficult to dismiss outright. One can reject the radical claim that "reality is discursively constructed," while still recognizing that our language system does help to shape the way in which we view reality. It is not very difficult for kritik debaters to win that discourse matters and that questions of discourse are worth talking about. In countering this claim, one can point out that there are dangers as well as benefits to discursive analysis. The exclusive focus on words can lead to the neglect of important non-verbal realities, including actual human suffering. Verbal disputes are often sterile-- "it's just a question of semantics." The mid-twentieth century linguistic turn in Anglo-American philosophy produced some classic works, such as Austin's on performative statements, but few would now regard it as a philosophic renaissance. (Indeed, critics like Bertrand Russell came to ultimately dismiss it as "the abdication of philosophy.") John Rawls' *A Theory of Justice* revolutionized modern political theory because it offered a substantive theory of distributive justice, not just analysis of what the word "justice" means to people. All this said, one can still agree that there is an appropriate time and place for linguistic, semantic, discursive, and rhetorical analysis. But in the context of a policy debate, questions of discourse are secondary.

A critique of the term, "terrorist," for example, might help to illuminate the debate over the Patriot Act, but it would probably not decisively determine the outcome of that debate. Even if "one man's terrorist is another man's freedom fighter," Americans might well decide that they want better protection against such fighters for freedom. The term "proliferation" might be suspect in the context of nuclear weapons because it carries connotations of the uncontrolled spread of cancerous cells. Despite this negative connotation, however, authors like Kenneth Waltz manage to argue that nuclear "proliferation" could be good. And somehow the kritik of proliferation discourse does not make the prospect of North Korean nuclear weapons seem much more appealing.

Many kritiks, both of older and of more recent vintage, have chosen to focus on questions of overarching political ideology. Thus, we have kritiks of capitalism, realism,

rights, the law, the border, and the state launched by radical environmentalists, feminists, and critical theorists of all stripes. These kritiks are often interesting, and they often seem more relevant to policy debate than do kritiks of discourse or of metaphysical assumptions. Still, the ideological kritik remains in some ways intellectually unsatisfying. Broad ideological perspectives are often illuminating, but they are rarely decisive in the context of a proposal for incremental policy change. Even if the state is on balance bad, in a world of entrenched nation states, certain actions by the state could well be good. These kritiks also stumble over the problem of ideological transformation. Even if deep ecology is preferable to shallow environmentalism, the endorsement of deep ecology in a debate round does not instill its principles in everyone's heart.

Another critical theme has been that we should use debate rounds to formulate activist strategies for change. This approach has an articulate exponent in Gordon Mitchell, but it still poses problems especially as it has been implemented in practice. First, there is the question of relevance to the kinds of topics we typically debate. If the affirmative says that "the state should do X," a negative response that "activist strategy Y would be the best way to persuade the state to do X" does not seem competitive. It supplements what the affirmative says, rather than disagreeing with it. Second, few if any kritiks that I have heard would do much to enlighten activist's actual practice. Most kritiks reek of the rhetoric of the academic, if adversarial, ivory tower. Mainstream rights talk seems more likely than the kritik of rights to advance activist interests in the real world. Third, there is the problem of premature activism. Responsible activism requires a well-reasoned set of substantive beliefs. Academic debate does help people to sort through and establish their substantive opinions, and I think that it does this far more effectively than it can illuminate subtle and situational issues of activist strategy.

These are only some of the approaches to argument which critical debaters have employed. Others, such as the notion of kritik as "rethinking," proved relatively short-lived. Still others, including ethical kritiks, proved relatively easy to incorporate into mainstream policy debate, for example, in the form of deontological disadvantages. More recently,

debate has to some extent turned away from issues of discourse and assumptions, ideology and activism, to a focus on performance, representations, and methodology. Each of these newer approaches merits at least brief comment.

The idea that debate is a performance has encouraged the use of mixed media presentations, including music and film, within debates. Such "performances" are no doubt often more interesting and esthetically engaging than the usual debate drone. But it is quite unclear that they constitute intellectually sound forms of argument. The fact that some rap artist may oppose capital punishment or favor massive transfers of land back into the hands of Native Americans strikes me as a rather weak appeal to authority. But perhaps I lack proper reverence for the prophetic powers of hip-hop. Nor does the manipulative nature of some SUV ads seem like a compelling ground for government-imposed restrictions on the use of fossil fuels. One can agree that debate is a performance, while still believing that it is a particular kind of performance, one in which rational argument is central. My most minimalist notion of what debate should be is that it ought to involve giving good reasons in support of a given claim. In light of this, the problem with incorporating rap lyrics into debate is that despite their rhyme and their rhythm, they fail to articulate reasons in support of the emotional attitudes they express. My position, of course, is decidedly intellectualist, and I recognize that even the notion of "rationality" is an embattled one. What constitute "good reasons" remains and should remain perpetually open to debate. Academic debate, if it chooses to, can devalue logos in favor of pathos. To do so, I think, would represent a dreadful departure from our main educational mission. If America's public discourse focused more on the articulation of good reasons and less on appeals to prejudice and preconception, it would be less pathetic.

"Performance" has taken on another meaning in debate, one derived from Austin's concept of performative utterance. In sum, a performative statement is one that does something, rather than simply asserting that something is the case. So, for instance, the words, "I now pronounce you husband and wife," change the legal status of the two people being married. How do words uttered in a debate *do things*? The answer most often given

seems to be that they define the debaters who speak them as certain kinds of people. If you speak words of radical criticism, you become a radical social critic. If you speak words of racial compassion, you become a compassionate egalitarian. Perhaps I have not quite captured this (to me at least) rather elusive concept. At any rate, the notion of self-definition through argument seems to be the gist of this concept of debate "performance."

What can one make of this rather interesting idea? First, to me at least, comes the perhaps ungenerous thought that talk, especially in a debate round, is cheap. Words are not deeds, and the words spoken in debates are further insulated from consequence by the provisional and strategic nature of most debate argument. We don't commonly expect debaters to really mean what they say in debate rounds--and even when they say that they really mean it, there is considerable room for doubt. After all, they may just be trying to win the debate. Second, though, and more fundamentally, it is not clear why one should vote for a team because they have defined themselves through their arguments in a certain way. Is it because it makes them especially virtuous and therefore praiseworthy? But virtue is supposed to be its own reward. Nor is virtue (let alone self-righteousness) a guarantor that one's arguments are sound. Finally, if argument is self-defining, then it applies to both sides. If the critical debater is self-defined through argument as compassionate and utopian, then the anti-critical debater is likely to be self-defined as a pragmatic problem solver. The familiar dispute between utopianism and pragmatism, which has been central to debates for over twenty years, may thus be pushed to another level, but the core controversy remains the same.

A focus on the "representations" employed in debates has, of late, to some extent displaced the previous concentration on discourse. While discourse focuses on the words employed, representations involve the broader images that those words create and convey. Nonetheless, the problems associated with representational focus in policy debate are rather similar to those linked to discursive focus. First, if one is proposing a plan of action, the representations employed are secondary and instrumental means of justifying an ultimate policy conclusion. Thus, even if representations are in part discredited, the overall policy

conclusion may hold. Second, representations are always partial, always limited by personal perspective, and always prone to interpretation. There is no such thing as an absolutely clear, perfectly accurate representation of something. We thus can quibble endlessly about the correctness of an image. But the fact remains that we are forced ultimately to act on the basis of imperfect depictions and recognitions.

So-called "methodological" kritiks have also become fashionable recently. Such positions are not, on face, illegitimate; there is nothing wrong with arguing that traditional methods of proof (science, empiricism, expert testimony, for example) are defective and that alternative modes of argument (personal narratives, irony, poetry, etc.) are superior. I expect that if the merits of the more traditional and the more innovative modes of argument are debated out in a rigorous way that the more mainstream approaches will prevail. But that seems like a debate worth having; my main complaint is that it has not thus far occurred in an at all sophisticated way. That said, it is still worth noting that the focus on methodology can be overdone. (It is, after all, the quintessence of "instrumental rationality.") Most methods have some merit; most modes of proof have some probative value. The real question is just how much weight they should carry in a given context. And it should also be remembered that method is not an end in itself. Rather, it is a means to reaching other conclusions. After the debate over method, one must still *apply* the available methods to the issue at hand.

What can we conclude from this survey of some of the different forms which critical argument in academic debate has taken? First, we should note the shifting, protean nature of critical argument. Whereas policy debate has tended towards consensus concerning standards of argument, critical debate has settled on no fixed theory. Its standards and conventions have continued to evolve. The skeptic might say that this is because kritiks tend to win by perpetually shifting the grounds of argument—from policy conclusions to assumptions, ideologies, discourses, ethics, activism, performance, methodology, representations, and so on. Second, something which may be less clear from this brief history, but which I nonetheless strongly believe is the case, is that critical

argument has become more radical over time. This is not to deny that some of the early kritiks were radical enough--they indicted, among other things, rationality, causality, and normative argument in general. But by and large, the earlier kritiks were closer to the policy concerns indicated by the debate topic. They tended to concentrate on policy assumptions, policy discourse, political ideology, the ethical groundings of policy, etc.

More recent kritiks, in contrast, seem to have turned inward, stressing the personal concerns and priorities of the participants. Personal narrative, personal self-expression, and self-definition have become central to many kritik debates. And the methods of argument employed--including music, literature, and film--have departed more and more from the methods of the traditional debate speech. This second conclusion, however, must be qualified by a third: that a significant split has occurred within the kritik camp itself. Thus, we have what might be dubbed the "traditional" kritik mode. This is analytical, generally philosophical, generally grounded in secondary sources, involving large amounts of direct quotation, and usually delivered at the standard rapid debate rate. In sum, to the uninitiated observer, this type of critical debate would not sound much different from traditional policy debate. In contrast, we now also have what Ryan Galloway terms the performance mode of criticism. This tends to be more rhetorical, more self-referential, and it usually employs a far slower style of delivery.

What led to the rise of critical argument in policy debate? And what in particular encouraged the development of the more radical, performance mode of argument? Not surprisingly, these developments reflect forces both within debate and from outside it. The rise to academic prominence of postmodernist, post-structuralist, and critical theories probably made something like the kritik inevitable. Indeed, it is almost surprising that critical argument did not emerge sooner. It is not surprising that a debate theorist and practitioner as creative as Bill Shanahan would eventually apply to debate some of the advanced academic constructs and concepts in which he is interested. The oppositional politics of the academic left also influenced the rise and the evolution of critical argument. Identity politics, especially the politics of race and gender, is a third factor. Again, it is not

shocking that people for whom these are central personal and political concerns would try to find ways to employ and express these preoccupations in debate. Finally, there is the "expressive individualism" associated with therapeutic culture. Individualism and self-expression are not exactly new themes. They were expounded in their classic forms by such nineteenth century liberals as Emerson, Thoreau, and John Stuart Mill. Still, the 1960s are, I think, properly perceived as giving birth to a new emphasis on self-expression. And this new emphasis occurred in a culture which viewed self-expression as therapeutic. The famous "talking cure" of Freudian psychoanalysis may have begun this trend, but Freud had many successors among humanistic as well as popular "self-help" psychologists. In the 1960s, "doing one's own thing" and "letting it all hang out" became hallmarks of authenticity. On a somewhat higher level, existentialism popularized a view of human beings as self-defining and self-creating entities. I do not think that it is too fanciful to see some of these themes as playing themselves out in contemporary kritik debates.

Expressive individualism has had many critics, both from the right (Robert Bork, Gertrude Himmelfarb, William Bennett, Allan Bloom, etc.) and the left (Robert Bellah, Amitai Etzioni, and Christopher Lasch, among others). Lasch's 1979 book, *The Culture of Narcissism*, is perhaps the most comprehensive as well as the most compelling discussion of this theme. Lasch was an imminent intellectual historian whose academic career included appointments at both Rochester and Northwestern, as well as a penetrating cultural critic. Reflecting back on the "me decade" of the 1970s, Lasch saw narcissistic self-absorption as the hallmark of our time. In a later work, *The Revolt of the Elites* (1995), he linked the withdrawal of academic intellectuals into their own esoteric preoccupations with "the democratic malaise" and even the decline of democratic debate. Lasch writes:

Since the public no longer participates in debates on national issues, it has no reason to inform itself about civic affairs. It is the decline of public debate...that makes the public so ill-informed... What democracy requires is vigorous public, debate, not just information. Of course, it needs information too, but the kind of information it needs can be generated only by debate. We do not know what we

need to know until we ask the right questions, and we can identify the right questions only by subjecting our own ideas about the world to the test of public controversy. (pp. 162-163)

Another important work of cultural criticism, Robert Hughes' *The Culture of Complaint* (1993), sounds similar themes. For Hughes, an award-winning historian and art critic, the central theme of contemporary culture is the broad embrace of the role of the victim. For him, we have become a culture of whiners who ignore progressive developments and focus reflexively (and self-reflexively) on the negative. A fair number of critical debates seem to embody Hughes' culture of complaint.

Lasch and Hughes are sweeping and controversial cultural critics, and I am far from fully embracing their views of contemporary culture. Nor would I contend that critical argument expresses, part and parcel, a culture of narcissism. (Whatever else it may be, Gordon Mitchell's call for an "outward, activist turn" in debate is hardly narcissistic. Indeed, his position would seem to dovetail nicely with that of Lasch on the importance of democratic debate.) But the more radical, performance-oriented kritiks, with their emphasis on self-expression, personal experience, self-definition, and insistence on talking about matters of intimate personal concern seem to reflect a withdrawal from the public sphere into the realms of the personal and the therapeutic. A similar point can be made about kritiks so steeped in advanced academic theories as to be unintelligible to most debaters as well as the public at large. This seems to be part of the revolt of the elites (and their withdrawal from meaningful engagement in the public sphere) which Lasch indicts. I am far from thinking that all forms of expressive individualism are evil. In the various spheres of art and philosophy, they certainly have their place. But debate is a cooperative as well as a competitive endeavor, and when one half of a debate insists on only talking about what they want to talk about both the cooperation and the competition are likely to break down. To some extent, of course, policy-oriented debaters do the same thing. But at least they have the sanction of the topic, which is arrived at consensually by the debate community at large and which usually focuses on issues of general public interest and importance.

The rise and radicalization of the kritik is also the result of factors internal to debate itself. With the popularization of tabula rasa judging an implicit view seems to have emerged that debate should be a pure argument game, rather than an argument game with a specific content-public policy. This opened the door to arguments that radically questioned the prevailing policy framework. Another factor that has certainly contributed, especially to the development of the kritik's more radical forms, is the widespread employment of increasingly sophisticated forms of mutual preference judging. When teams employing radically innovative strategies can count on consistently debating in front of the twenty or so percent of the judging pool most favorable to their approach, departures from the mainstream are encouraged.

Whatever genealogy of critical argument one may construct, kritiks are an entrenched part of competitive NDT/CEDA debate. A significant percentage of nationally competitive teams (thirty to forty percent?) rely heavily on critical arguments, while a smaller (but still quite conspicuous) percentage employ the more radical, performance oriented strategies. Is this unfortunate? I believe in the end that it is, but it should be noted that on face there are certain benefits to the status quo. There are still lots of debates about politics and policy for those who wish to have them. These are educational, in their own way, but critical debates, raising different themes and employing different modes and styles of argument, are also educational. Many debaters and coaches obviously find critical arguments to be engaging and appealing. The existence of these argumentative options within debate encourages the participation of this part of the debate community.

What, then, is the problem? First, for me critical debate is ultimately unsatisfying intellectually because it fails to directly engage the topic. When, pursuant to a proposition of policy, the affirmative proposes a plan of action, the negative will frequently respond not by attacking that plan's desirability but by indicting assumptions, ideologies, discourses or representations associated with that policy. To employ the language of Wittgenstein, the affirmative makes a move within one language game, and the negative responds with strategies appropriate to other, sometimes radically different, language games.

Second, the quality of most critical debates remains relatively low. In part, this is the fault of policy-oriented debaters, who consistently fail to engage critical arguments meaningfully on their own merits. But it also reflects the fact that the radical disorientation of the opponent is a central part of the critical strategy. The proliferation of new frameworks does not, encourage good debates. Debate, like chess, is a hard enough game to play without making it a three-dimensional. Furthermore, when one side introduces a new, innovative framework, they will almost inevitably use that framework to tilt the playing field in their favor. In the case of critical affirmatives, the affirmative will frequently fail to really endorse the topic and instead will endorse some factual or moral truism, for example, that minority participation in debate should be increased. Even when the proposed framework does not so flagrantly favor one side, that is, when there is real, viable ground available to both teams, that ground will be quite unfamiliar to the team responding to the non-traditional framework. The critical team will debate their own, self-selected, arguments round after round, sometimes year after year. Even if the opposing team knows what is coming, they are required to research and develop a totally unique strategy which they will probably get to employ only once or twice. And by the time one framework has been figured out, there may well be a new framework to decipher and debate.

Third, one result of this is the proliferation of unsatisfying and ultimately not very educational theory debates. If theory debates were commonly about what constitutes good argument, it would be one thing. Typically, though, theory debates focus on what is fair within the competitive debate format. This is quite esoteric, and it is ultimately trivial. The theory of the fair debate format is not a body of knowledge which will serve students well in their post-debate lives. Nonetheless, the emergence of critical argument has produced a vast body of new debate theory. And the more radical the culture split within debate, the more theory argument is encouraged. The more complex the body of debate theory, the harder it is for people to learn to debate. Policy debate was a complex and difficult game in itself. Now the novice debater must not only learn the policy game, he or she must also learn to play a whole range of critical debate games. Some debaters, of course, only learn to

play one kind of kritik game extremely well. This may make it easier for the less experienced to win debates (though the successful deployment of critical strategies also, empirically, takes years to learn), but it also undercuts the value of argumentative pluralism within debate. Policy debate and critical debate may both have educational values, but it is generally just the policy debaters who reap these educational benefits, since they are forced to debate in both policy and critical modes. Pure kritik debaters, in contrast, will almost never engage in public policy argument directly. Thus, the education they receive from debate is often quite narrow. Finally, it is worth noting that theory wars are generally indecisive. Zarefsky and others came to recognize that the problem with paradigm wars was that different paradigms rest upon incommensurate values and worldviews. This was true in the 1970s, and it seems even more so today. Contemporary "framework" debates are rarely decisively or effectively argued. Yet they seem unavoidable since the force of critical arguments usually depends upon the framework employed.

Fourth, critical argument can be anti-educational for those employing it. Radical criticism insists on the virtue of debaters drawing on personal experience to speak to those questions which matter the most to them. Perhaps this creates a sense of empowerment. It also, however, virtually ensures that these debaters will not engage themselves in considering other questions and other viewpoints. A central value of education is that it draws us out of ourselves, beyond our immediate experiences, and leads us encounter new subjects and new perspectives. One appealing, if idealistic, view of debate is that its central purpose is to find truth. Radical criticism, both in debate and often outside of it, seems to begin with the premise that it knows the truth and is morally compelled to proclaim it from the mountaintop. Thus, critical debaters are frequently unwilling to really debate both sides of the topic, unwilling even for a moment to hypothetically engage in a perspective opposed to their own. Sometimes, of course, critical debaters are unwilling to engage either side of a debate topic, being so immersed in their own intellectual interests and personal concerns that they have no interest in energy policy, treaty commitments, or America's relations with Europe.

Kritik debaters often indict "experts" because of their narrowly focused specialization. But radical critics are the ultimate debate specialists. They acquire extreme expertise in the execution of certain themes and forms of argument. As a result, they generally fail to engage with the broader range of issues that more mainstream debaters commonly encounter. Radical kritik is sometimes strong on persuasion and conviction, but it is all too often short on critical thinking and especially self-criticism. Reliance on experts obviously has its dangers, though it is difficult to avoid in a complex world in which the experts usually know a lot more about a given subject than one does oneself. (This is, of course, the ultimate rationale for the employment of experts, whether they are doctors, lawyers, auto mechanics, scholars, or debate coaches.) But reliance on personal experience is also no panacea. One's personal experience may not be representative. It is also filtered through the opaque glass of all of our own prejudices and preconceptions, most of which we acquire from our close social associates. And personal experience is subject to interpretation and reinterpretation. A given "experience" can have many interpretations, all partial, all selective, some paranoid. A salutary skepticism towards the experts should be accompanied by an equally important skepticism with regards to our own infallibility.

Fifth, the culture split within debate has also led to a good deal of personal frustration and even antagonism. Though I am sure that the kritik camp has its own share of frustrations (due, for example, to judges who they think won't give their arguments a fair hearing), I am personally more attuned to the frustrations of policy coaches and debaters. There is, after all, a contingent of people in debate who have a deep and abiding interest in matters of public policy. They are assigned to debate a policy topic. But in critical debates, they are not allowed to explore the issues in which they are really interested. Instead, they encounter opponents who are passionately committed to talking about a very different set of issues, often in what sounds like a totally different language. A huge number of kritik wins are scored against opponents who really don't understand the argument by which they have been defeated. (I'm sure this is far less often the case in policy debates.) Some of this is the fault of the non-critical debaters--they could do better scouting and spend more time

learning about post-structuralist philosophy and critical theory. But part of the problem is that criticism in debate encourages the perpetual reinvention of debate theory, including the employment of unfamiliar and poorly articulated frameworks. Of course, the frustration factor does cut both ways. My point here is not to assign blame or to measure relative victimization. Rather, it is to point out that debate's cultural cleavage can produce considerable frustration for those on both sides of the divide. This frustration is definitely heightened when there is no general agreement about the basic shape of debate, no agreement on a *core* conception of the activity's nature. As I noted at the outset of this piece, there have probably always been cleavages within the debate community. But never before, in my memory, has there been such deep disagreement concerning fundamentals. Lincoln famously observed that a house divided cannot stand. Debate's house is still standing, but the family it contains seems increasingly dysfunctional.

Overt antagonism is the most distressing sign that this shotgun marriage of debate cultures is indeed in trouble. In fairness, I would say that debaters and coaches have done a surprisingly good job of remaining collegial throughout the critical culture wars. Across debate's cultural divide, we are still united by ties of personal respect and friendship. But there are signs that these ties are beginning to fray. One problem with arguing for what you feel and care about most deeply is that attacks on your arguments tend to become personal attacks. The loss of a debate becomes both a personal rejection and a setback for one's most deeply felt social cause. On the other side, those forced to debate against these highly personal kritiks are likely to be cast in the role of the villain, as active or at least complicit agents of racism, for example. And even those who have invested years of effort in the pursuit of racial inclusiveness in debate, for example, through work with urban debate leagues, are likely to find their exertions scorned. This is, to say the least, unpleasant, and at some point, I fear, it will begin to drive people from the activity.

Pluralism and multiculturalism can work toward tolerance and a live and let live attitude. They entail a certain price in social fragmentation, but that price is probably worth paying if it allows the coexistence of differences to which various groups are deeply

committed. But multiculturalism works far better in the private than in the public sphere. In private, different groups can pursue their own interests and traditions without, for the most part, interfering with the practices of other groups. But, in public, where different groups interact, it is necessary that there be some common standards of conduct. And it is here that debate's multiculturalism stumbles. It's hard to have a good game when the two sides want to play distinctly different sports.

But this impasse is easier to condemn than to successfully resolve. As with all culture wars, both sides are deeply committed. Both sides feel that core values are at stake, and both sides manage to combine hefty doses of both self-righteousness and self-interest. So what do we do?

I see three basic ways of reconciling the present division within debate: secession, exclusion, and synthesis. The secession option would involve those most committed to policy debate withdrawing from current debate structures and forming their own explicitly policy-oriented debate league. The Policy Round Robin is a very modest effort along these lines. The ADA represents a more sweeping instance of the same approach. Secession, however, rarely works when one side refuses to let go, as the American South was finally forced to recognize. Nor has secession been too successful in debate. The great CEDA and NDT divorce eventually proved unsustainable. Similarly, if policy debaters withdrew, kritik debaters would probably follow them, bringing their judges, and proceeding to subvert the hegemony of policy argument once again from within. (It is interesting that while policy debaters would probably like to be left alone to play together quietly; kritik debaters seem to have no such desire. Why is there no Kritik Round Robin or Kritik Debate Association? I suspect it is because critical argument is ultimately parasitic on policy debate. It is large, lethargic policy debaters who it is easiest for kritikers to disconcert and devour. If critical debaters were forced to live exclusively off of each other, they would find the pickings far slimmer.) Even successful secession, however, would be problematic unless a large enough part of the debate community could be induced to defect. Too small a secessionist movement would ultimately dwindle into non-viability.

Exclusion is a rather nasty word, and I am not in general in favor of writing rules to ban arguments you cannot otherwise defeat. Still, if one finds certain structures moving debate in a direction of which one disapproves, it is not unreasonable to reconsider the desirability of those incentive structures. The main structural feature in present debate which encourages the more radical forms of criticism is probably highly refined mutual preference judging. Forcing debaters to debate for a wider range of judges, in contrast, would encourage adaptation at minimum and perhaps more mainstream arguments generally. We may eventually come to this, but I don't think that time is yet at hand. Almost everyone likes highly selective mutual preference judging for themselves. Thus, the policy debate contingent seems unlikely to pay the price in terms of their own judge preferences that it would take to deny highly preferred judges to the ranks of the critical.

So, we come to consider how critical and policy approaches could find some measure of synthesis and reconciliation. In doing this, it is perhaps best to begin by considering just what are the best features of both critical and policy debate. There are several aspects of critical debate which I regard favorably. First, critical debaters generally employ a slower, more pleasant and publicly accessible style of delivery. When kritikers do go fast they tend, because of the content of their arguments, to be even less intelligible than policy debaters. Still, it is generally slower and therefore more intelligible to both the debate-trained and the uninitiated. I have believed for a long time that debate's delivery conventions are both anti-intellectual and damaging to the activity. There is a reason why "fast talkers" have a bad name. In addition, debate's rapid delivery convention makes it inaccessible to the general public, something that cannot help when it comes to institutional support.

Second, critical debaters are less obsessive in their reliance on the direct quotation of expert sources. Our vast reliance on direct quotation is a rhetorical device ill suited to employment in any other context, except perhaps the research paper. If one thinks that debate should be more about thinking and arguing than about reading, then the cult of the

direct quote seems misguided, tending both towards intellectual plagiarism and to the exaggeration of the "magical" power-worded card.

Third, some of the themes which critical argument explores are intellectually substantive and engaging. Personally, I find the issues of moral and political philosophy which kritiks have helped to raise to be interesting and worthwhile. And these are issues it is difficult to incorporate into incrementalist modes of policy analysis. The insistence on uniqueness, whatever its other merits, does make the consideration of fundamental alternatives difficult.

Fourth, critical argument is of some help in countering the "just a game" view of debate. I am not unsympathetic to the desire to make debate matter more than this. Of course, I also think that policy debate topics raise real issues about which people should care. But when debate is treated just as a game, even if an educational one, the significance of what we are doing and discussing can easily be lost. It is not only critical debate which has tried to make debate matter more; hypothesis testing, with its insistence that debate should be a search for truth, also attempted this. If educational and truth values were held more highly in debate and competitive values stressed somewhat less, I think that it would be good for the activity.

Just as the policy-oriented can learn something from the critical, critical debaters have some lessons they could take from policy debate. First, the insistence, associated with policy debate, that teams debate the topic (and indeed both sides of the topic) is beneficial both educationally and competitively. An informed view of a fairly wide range of public policy issues seems invaluable whether one is a policy maker, a policy scholar, a social critic, a social activist, an interested citizen, or even a person with good grounds for social disaffiliation. Changing the topic each year encourages debaters to engage intellectually with a wide range of issues, and switch sides debating encourages debaters to look at both sides of controversial issues. Competitively, a set topic is good because we can write topics which are reasonably balanced, as well as reasonable in scope and depth.

Second, kritik debaters, at least some of them, could learn to be less dogmatic. They could afford to be less confident of their personal opinions and experiences, both of which are interpreted through filters of selective perception and interpretation. They could afford to be more interested in the views of others, especially the much maligned expert.

Third, some kritik debaters seem afflicted with one of Nietzsche's particular aversions, "the spirit of seriousness." The rhetoric of the moral high ground, of which many kritik debaters are fond, easily enough translates into self-righteousness. While I am sympathetic with the view that debate should be something more than just a game, it remains a game as well. I doubt that anyone lasts long in this activity who is not highly competitive. The claim made by some critical debater (and coaches) that they don't care about winning simply defies credulity. The fate of the earth is really not at stake in debate rounds, however often we may quote Jonathan Schell. The notion that debaters possess vast amounts of "agency," permitting them, for example, to supercharge social movements is a narcissistic fantasy at best. If we remember the limits of our influence, as well as the competitive incentives we all experience, perhaps we will be less likely to beatify ourselves and to demonize our opponents.

Is there a way to combine the better aspects of critical debate with the more desirable parts of the policy approach? My synthesis, my imagined debate utopia, would look something like this. First, debate would be considerably slower; fast-talking would cease to be a central part of the game. Second, we would still consult the work of experts, but we would be less obsessive about direct quotation; more paraphrases and footnoting would be acceptable. Third, we would place at least a little more emphasis on truth-values in argument. If debaters want what they are doing to have more real world significance, one way to accomplish this would be to argue for what they really believe, at least insofar as the topic at hand permits. They could seek the intellectually strongest case, rather than the most strategic one. Further, this could be undertaken in an enquiring rather than a dogmatic spirit. We could really think of debate as a way of examining our ideas by exposing them "to the test of public controversy." I think that some of my neo-conservative debaters might

welcome this challenge. But this kind of real intellectual testing of arguments can only occur if debate becomes less of an esoteric technical game and more a substantive, scholarly activity.

There may be some ways in which some of the more interesting critical arguments could be more congruously incorporated into policy debate. I have suggested for a number of years (without, alas, stimulating much interest) that the various ideological kritiks could be made more relevant to policy debate by framing them as ideological disadvantages. The ideological disadvantage would employ a two-step process. First, it would argue that a given ideological framework (deep ecology, socialism, libertarianism, or what have you) is optimal and should be embraced. Second, it would make arguments that someone who had chosen to accept that ideology would reject the plan. The ideological disadvantage is clearly policy relevant; indeed, it is framed as a reason to reject the plan. But it offers a more philosophical way of approaching policy and finesses the uniqueness issue by rejecting incrementalist decision-making. The affirmative, of course, would be free to argue that we should be incrementalists rather than ideologues and that we should not forego utilitarian benefits for the sake of ideological purity. But presumably this is a debate which those committed to ideological consistency (a stance which the present ideological kritiks seem to assume) would be willing to undertake. Discursive arguments could also be given greater force within policy debate by arguing that disadvantages can be linked to the discourse employed by the affirmative. This is not unreasonable--when policies are enacted in the real world, people are aware of the reasons given for their enactment. Thus, for example, anti-corporate rhetoric could be a link to business confidence. Neo-Malthusian rhetoric might be a link to relations disadvantages. The core idea, at any rate, would be to make the affirmative (and the negative) more responsible for the rationales it advances by letting disadvantages be linked to their policy logic as well as their policy actions.

A final way to bridge the canyon between critical and policy debate might be to employ multiple topics. For me, probably the biggest problem with most kritiks is that they are not compelling arguments in the context of a policy topic. This does not mean that they

do not (sometimes) raise interesting issues that are worthy of debate. But if, in fact, these issues are worthwhile, we could write non-policy topics in which they would be clearly relevant. So, for example, if we wanted to debate an ideological issue, we could write a topic such as "Resolved: deep ecology, social ecology, or ecofeminism should be embraced as a lens through which to view environmental issues." Or a discursive topic could be constructed, such as "Resolved: that the rhetoric of terror talk and the war on terror should be rejected." Or a topic of personal action and commitment could be framed, such as "Resolved: individuals should adopt less consumptive life styles." Or a topic of activism might read, "Resolved: local activism is superior to activism at the national level where environmental issues are concerned." These are crude examples and would require refinement, and construction of good non-policy topics would require thought and practice. Still, I see no compelling reason why good non-policy topics could not be constructed.

So much for my utopian fantasy. Doubtless, for most of you it is dystopian. My conclusion is that debate's cultural rift is unlikely to be healed any time soon because both sides are so deeply committed to doing debate the way they want to do it. If and when critical and post-modern fashions wane in academia, critical argument will likely wane as well. Or debate might experience an internal revolution as extreme as the critical turn itself has been. But, till then, our cultures will continue to clash, with Will Repko and David Heidt forced to decide these conflicts of the incommensurate.

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